Week 2: Positivity, Telephone and Non-verbal Communication

NPTEL Soft Skills · Prof. Binod Mishra · Lectures 6–10

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Lecture 6: Positive Thinking

Week 2 · Course book PDF pages 84–99 (printed pages 83–98)

Learning objectives

- Define positive thinking and distinguish optimists from pessimists.
- Explain Eric Berne's four life positions (I'm OK, you're OK, etc.).
- Describe the Johari Window and its four areas, and how each area can be expanded.
- State ways of developing positivism using examples from the lecture.

Important definitions

POSITIVE THINKING

Norman Vincent Peale (*The Power of Positive Thinking*): a positive mental attitude that firmly believes things will soon be better and so overcomes difficulty.

OPTIMIST / PESSIMIST

An optimist looks at the bright side (glass half full) and creates opportunities; a pessimist looks at the dark side (glass half empty) and finds negativity in every opportunity.

JOHARI WINDOW

A model devised by American psychologists **Joseph Luft and Harry Ingham in 1955** to illustrate and improve self-awareness and mutual understanding in a group through disclosure and feedback.

OPEN AREA

Known to the person and known to others; it can be expanded through open, positive communication, feedback and interaction.

BLIND AREA

Not known to the person but known to others; reduced through non-judgmental feedback.

HIDDEN AREA

Known to the person but kept hidden from others; reduced through self-disclosure, which builds trust.

UNKNOWN AREA

Unknown to the person and unknown to others (latent talents); uncovered through mutual or collective discovery.

Core concepts

Why positive thinking helps

- A positive person believes 'I can do it' and so makes a good leader, entrepreneur and risk-taker.
- One who never takes risks never gains.
- William James: "We are only half awake" – we use only a small part of our physical and mental resources; discover your limits and hidden powers.
- A new player who faces the game positively can win.

Eric Berne's attitudes (life positions)

- **I'm not OK, you're not OK** – introvert; cannot proceed.
- **I'm not OK, you're OK** – negative.
- **I'm OK, you're not OK** – imposing (only he matters).
- **I'm OK, you're OK** – positive and co-operative; ideal for teamwork.

How to develop positivism

- **Believe in your abilities** and be yourself; you have immense untapped potential.
- **Do not blindly imitate** others; imitate only qualities that help you, without losing your own identity (story of the singer who hid her teeth).
- **Concentrate on your goals** and follow the right action; Gita: "Karmanye vadhikaraste ma phaleshu kadachana".
- People change: Roosevelt was physically weak; Demosthenes stuttered yet became a great orator.
- Dhammapada: "All that we are is the result of what we have thought."

Johari Window in groups

When a new person enters a group, not all of his skills are known to others or to himself. Group members should help him expose them. The window has four quadrants (areas). Feedback and self-

disclosure move information into the open area; the open area grows both horizontally and vertically. Managers can promote honest, non-judgmental feedback. Better self-awareness improves communication, relationships and productivity.

Types, classifications and characteristics

Johari Window quadrants

Quadrant	Known to self?	Known to others?	How to expand / reduce
1. Open (arena)	Yes	Yes	Open positive communication, feedback, solicitation
2. Blind	No	Yes	Non-judgmental feedback from managers/members
3. Hidden	Yes	No	Self-disclosure; reduce hidden area to build trust
4. Unknown	No	No	Mutual discovery, new experiences

Berne's life positions

Attitude	Type of person
I'm not OK, you're not OK	Introvert
I'm not OK, you're OK	Negative
I'm OK, you're not OK	Imposing
I'm OK, you're OK	Positive and co-operative

Theories, principles, models and contributors

TRANSACTIONAL ANALYSIS ATTITUDES — DR. ERIC BERNE

Four conclusions about human attitudes, ranging from 'I'm not OK, you're not OK' to the healthy 'I'm OK, you're OK'.

JOHARI WINDOW — JOSEPH LUFT AND HARRY INGHAM (1955)

The name combines the first names Joe and Harry. Four areas: open, blind, hidden, unknown.

POSITIVE MENTAL ATTITUDE — NORMAN VINCENT PEALE

Author of *The Power of Positive Thinking*.

Examples and applications

EXAMPLE

Half-full versus half-empty glass of water.

EXAMPLE

A singer who hid her teeth was told to rely on her voice and talent.

EXAMPLE

Demosthenes' stutter and Roosevelt's weakness were overcome through practice.

EXAMPLE

Latent talent: someone discovers a good singing voice only when a situation draws it out (unknown area).

Comparison tables

Optimist versus pessimist

Point	Optimist	Pessimist
Glass of water	Half full	Half empty
View	Bright side; creates opportunity	Dark side; negativity in every opportunity

Important facts for MCQ revision

EXAM TIP

- Glass half empty = pessimist; half full = optimist.
- Peale wrote *The Power of Positive Thinking*.
- William James: we are only half awake.
- 'I'm OK, you're OK' = positive and co-operative; 'I'm OK, you're not OK' = imposing; 'I'm not OK, you're not OK' = introvert; 'I'm not OK, you're OK' = negative.
- Johari Window: Luft and Ingham, 1955; four areas: open, blind, hidden, unknown.
- Blind area = unknown to self but known by others.
- Ways to develop positivism: believe in your abilities; concentrate on your goals.
- Gita quotation: Karmanye vadhikaraste ma phaleshu kadachana.
- Dhammapada: All that we are is the result of what we have thought.

QUIZ-RELATED CONCEPTS (QUIZ PDF PAGE REFERENCES)

Question	Quiz PDF page	Concept tested	Type
W2 Q1	p.7	Positive thinking	MCQ
W2 Q2	p.7	Berne's life positions (transactional analysis)	MCQ
W2 Q5	p.7	Johari Window	MCQ
W2 Q10	p.8	Developing positive thinking	MSQ
W6 Q9	p.23	Berne's life positions	MCQ

Full question text and answers: Quiz analysis.

Summary

Positive thinking is the belief that one can succeed; optimists create opportunities while pessimists see obstacles. Eric Berne's four attitudes show why 'I'm OK, you're OK' suits teamwork. The Johari Window (Luft and Ingham, 1955) uses four areas – open, blind, hidden, unknown – to show how feedback and disclosure increase self-awareness. Positivism is built by believing in one's abilities, not imitating blindly and pursuing one's goals.

Practice questions

Q1 (MCQ) In the Johari Window, the area unknown to the person but known to others is the:

A. Open area
B. Blind area
C. Hidden area
D. Unknown area

> **Answer:** B
> **Why:** Others see it; the person does not.

Q2 (MCQ) 'I'm OK, you're not OK' describes a person who is:

A. Positive
B. Negative
C. Imposing
D. Introvert

> **Answer:** C
> **Why:** Only he matters; others are disregarded.

Q3 (MSQ) Which are ways to develop positivism?

A. Believe in your abilities

B. Concentrate on your goals

C. Imitate others completely

D. Hide your weaknesses permanently

> **Answer:** A, B
> **Why:** The lecture warns against losing your own identity.

Q4 (T/F) The Johari Window was proposed by Eric Berne.

> **Answer:** False
> **Why:** It was proposed by Joseph Luft and Harry Ingham in 1955; Berne gave the OK attitudes.

Q5 (Fill) Reducing the _____ area through self-disclosure builds trust.

> **Answer:** hidden
> **Why:** It is known to oneself but concealed from others.

Q6 (Short) Why is 'I'm OK, you're OK' the ideal attitude at work?

> **Answer:** It is positive and co-operative, so it supports teamwork across different backgrounds.
> **Why:** Teams need co-operation.

Revision checklist

☐ I can distinguish optimist and pessimist.

☐ I can state all four life positions and their labels.

☐ I can define the four Johari areas with known/unknown to self and others.

☐ I know who proposed each theory and when.

☐ I can list ways to develop positivism.

Lecture 7: Telephonic Communication Skills Part I

Week 2 · Course book PDF pages 100–114 (printed pages 99–113)

Learning objectives

- Explain the importance of telephonic communication in life and business.
- List the special features of telephonic communication: clarity, courtesy, consideration, brevity.
- Apply the etiquette of making, receiving, transferring and closing calls.
- Handle complaints and voicemail professionally and avoid negative language.

Important definitions

TELEPHONIC COMMUNICATION

Sending and receiving messages through telephone instruments; the fastest and a low-cost means of contact across distance.

NETIQUETTE VERSUS ETIQUETTE

Netiquette is etiquette for internet communication; the lecturer notes that we forget basic etiquettes in the age of netiquettes.

VOICEMAIL

A recorded message left when the call cannot be completed; it should be complete.

Core concepts

Why telephones matter

- Bridge distance and time; fast, saves travel, cost-effective.
- Used to place orders, book tickets, give feedback, check quality, contact students, sellers and distributors.
- The reputation of an organisation depends on how its people communicate by phone.

Limitations

No face-to-face contact and no immediate visual feedback; the only cue is the voice. Video-calls are costly and not for everyone. Voice must carry assurance, sincerity, intimacy and enthusiasm.

Features of telephonic communication

1. **Clarity** – the first requirement.
2. **Courtesy** – right time, right address and tone; you cannot see the other person.
3. **Consideration** – empathy; the other party may be in a noisy or congested place; do not make them repeatedly ask “can you be loud?”.
4. **Brevity** – be brief and specific because someone is paying and time is limited.

While making a call

- Decide whether the call is necessary; if it can be avoided, avoid it.
- **Place your own call** instead of asking a secretary.
- **Plan an agenda** (purpose; keep pen and paper) to avoid repeated calls.
- **Identify yourself** and your affiliation (name, department, institute) and state the purpose.
- Address the person by name; avoid small talk such as "How is the weather?" in official calls.
- Speak clearly at a moderate volume; imagine you are speaking face to face.
- Close politely ("It was nice talking to you..."); never end abruptly.
- If the call is cut or you must stop, say you will call back, and call back when promised; leave a **complete voicemail** if needed.

While receiving a call

- Answer immediately, **not later than three rings**.
- Stop other conversation; identify yourself at once ("I am ... from ..., how may I help you?").
- Respond positively, even if you dislike the caller; "good gestures always mean good business".
- Take the message carefully: note caller's name (verify spelling), number and message and pass it on.
- To transfer a call, explain why and ask consent ("May I put you on hold?").
- For an angry complainant: stay calm, listen, note the concern, assure a response, and let the caller hang up first.

Language to use and avoid

- Avoid negatives such as "No, he is not here", "I cannot do that", "You have to...", "Why did you not...?".
- Use "Tell me what I can do for you", "I would like you to...", "Will/would you please...".

Types, classifications and characteristics

Four features of telephonic communication

Feature	Meaning
Clarity	Clear message and speech, whether giving or seeking information
Courtesy	Right time, right address, proper orientation without seeing the person
Consideration	Empathy for the other party's surroundings and state of mind
Brevity	Short and specific because of cost and the other person's time

Examples and applications

EXAMPLE

Opening a call: "Binod Mishra, Department of HSS, IIT Roorkee. May I speak to Mr X? The purpose of this call is..."

EXAMPLE

Closing a call: "It was nice talking to you, Mrs D'Souza. I have got the required information."

EXAMPLE

Receiving: “I am Jeethendra from NPTEL, how may I help you?”

Comparison tables

Making a call versus receiving a call

Making a call	Receiving a call
Plan an agenda, place own call	Answer within three rings
Identify yourself and purpose	Identify yourself immediately
Avoid small talk; be brief	Respond positively; take message accurately
Close courteously; call back if promised	Transfer only with consent; let the caller hang up

Important facts for MCQ revision

EXAM TIP

- Four features: clarity, courtesy, consideration, brevity.
- Clarity is the first requirement of telephonic communication.
- Answer a call within three rings.
- Place your own call and plan an agenda.
- Identify yourself with name and affiliation when calling and when receiving.
- Avoid small talk and negative words such as ‘No’ or ‘You have to’.
- Voice conveys reassurance, intimacy, sincerity; there is no immediate visual feedback.
- Telephone calls are fast and low cost, bridging distance.

QUIZ-RELATED CONCEPTS (QUIZ PDF PAGE REFERENCES)

Question	Quiz PDF page	Concept tested	Type
W2 Q6	p.8	Features of telephonic communication	MCQ
W2 Q11	p.9	Telephone etiquette: making a call	MSQ
W2 Q13	p.9	Importance of telephonic communication	MSQ

Full question text and answers: Quiz analysis.

Summary

Telephonic communication bridges time and distance quickly and at low cost but lacks visual feedback, so clarity, courtesy, consideration and brevity are essential. A caller should plan an agenda, place his own call, identify himself, state the purpose and close politely; a receiver should answer within three rings, identify himself, respond positively and take accurate messages. Negative language is avoided.

Practice questions

Q1 (MCQ) Which is the first and foremost feature of telephonic communication?

A. Brevity

B. Clarity

C. Humour

D. Confrontation

> **Answer:** B
> **Why:** The lecture lists clarity first.

Q2 (MCQ) A call should ideally be answered within:

A. One minute

B. Ten rings

C. Three rings

D. Whenever convenient

> **Answer:** C
> **Why:** Respond immediately, not more than after three rings.

Q3 (MSQ) Select the guidelines for sending a call.

A. Place your own call

B. Plan an agenda

C. Avoid identifying yourself

D. Recline in your chair

> **Answer:** A, B
> **Why:** Always identify yourself and prepare an agenda.

Q4 (T/F) In an official call it is good to begin with small talk about the weather.

> **Answer:** False
> **Why:** Small talk wastes money and time; be professional.

Q5 (Fill) While transferring a call, ask the caller's _____ and explain why you are transferring.

> **Answer:** consent
> **Why:** For example, "May I put you on hold?"

Q6 (Short) How should one respond to an angry customer on the phone?

> **Answer:** Stay calm, listen, note the concern, assure a response and allow the caller to hang up first.
> **Why:** This gives the caller more room.

Revision checklist

☐ I can list the four features of telephonic communication.
☐ I know the steps for making and receiving a call.
☐ I can rephrase negative sentences positively.
☐ I know the three-ring rule.
☐ I can describe how to take messages and transfer calls.

Lecture 8: Telephonic Communication Skills Part II

Week 2 · Course book PDF pages 115–126 (printed pages 114–125)

Learning objectives

- Explain voice mail, its advantages and limits, and how to leave and answer a voice message.
- State mobile (cell phone) etiquette.
- Differentiate teleconferencing (audio) and video conferencing, including the three types of video conferencing.
- Know when teleconferencing is ineffective and the cautions for video conferencing.

Important definitions

VOICE MAIL

A recorded-message facility that acts as a substitute for short memos and short phone calls, solves time-zone difficulties and reduces paperwork; messages are digitised and stored.

AUTOMATED ATTENDANT

A menu system (e.g. “for account balance press 1”) through which callers get information or record messages.

TELECONFERENCING

A telephonic meeting with more than two people, requiring a leader or facilitator; an alternative to a face-to-face meeting. Can be audio or video.

VIDEO CONFERENCING

Audio plus video link so that communication appears face to face; a tool of business and management for people separated by time and distance.

Core concepts

Voice mail: use and etiquette

- **Advantages:** substitute for short memos and phone calls; solves **time-zone difficulties**; reduces interoffice paperwork (paperless office); easy and low cost; can be replayed; can carry goodwill messages.
- **Limitation:** no immediate feedback; automated responses are general, not specific.
- **When leaving a message:** state your name clearly, give the point of the message, your phone number and the time/date you are available; avoid interrupting.
- **When replying:** reply quickly; listen again and write your response before returning the call.

Cell phone etiquette

- Speak in a **low, modulated tone**; do not shout (the Delhi bus example).
- Switch off or use silent mode in meetings, conferences, theatres, cinemas, temples, churches and classrooms; send a short message if a call is urgent.
- Do not call at odd hours unless urgent.
- Avoid talking in poor signal; suspend and resume later.
- Do not multitask (laptop plus call plus instructions) at the cost of courtesy; dial correctly to avoid wrong numbers.
- Phones are sensitive, so privacy is limited; keep private calls separate from official ones.

Teleconferencing

- Needs a leader/facilitator; can be arranged at **short notice**; connects geographically dispersed people; saves travel cost.
- Audio conferences give good sound quality when conference rooms and microphones are used.
- **Ineffective for negotiations** and decision-making because facial expressions and gestures cannot be read; little scope for secondary conversation; poor signals can defeat the purpose.

Video conferencing

- Emerging major tool for business and management; cheaper than journeys; top executives use it for decisions.
- Three types: **one-way video and one-way audio; two-way audio with one-way video; two-way video and two-way audio** (e.g. Skype, news-channel discussions).
- **Cautions:** check microphones and camera; introduce yourself (name, post, affiliation); control body movements; avoid parallel whispers; look at the camera; avoid distracting clothes and excessive movement.

Man is the master

“Technology should not become the master; man should become the master.” Be sensitive to others’ reactions, culture, time and energy.

Types, classifications and characteristics

Types of video conferencing (as described)

Type	Description
One-way video and one-way audio	Audio and video flow from one side to the other
Two-way audio with video one side	Both sides talk; one side sees
Two-way video and two-way audio	Both sides see and hear each other (Skype-like)

Examples and applications

EXAMPLE

Automated bank menu: “Welcome to SBI Credit Card... for account balance press 1.”

EXAMPLE

A passenger shouting instructions on a bus journey to Delhi.

EXAMPLE

News channel anchors connecting people at several locations through video conferencing.

Comparison tables

Audio teleconferencing versus video conferencing

Point	Teleconferencing (audio)	Video conferencing
Medium	Voice only	Voice plus video
Cues	Cannot read facial reactions or gestures	Body language visible; must control movements
Arrangement	Can be arranged at very short notice	Needs equipment; costlier but cheaper than travel
Use	Weak for negotiations	Used for decisions by busy executives

Important facts for MCQ revision

EXAM TIP

- Voice mail substitutes for short memos and phone calls and solves time-zone difficulties.
- Voice mail lacks immediate, specific feedback.
- Teleconferencing is ineffective for negotiations.
- Teleconferencing can be arranged at short notice and connects dispersed people.
- Three types of video conferencing (one-way, mixed, two-way).
- Speak in a low, modulated tone on cell phones; silent mode in meetings and worship places.
- Do not call at odd hours unless urgent.
- Teleconferencing needs a leader or facilitator.

QUIZ-RELATED CONCEPTS (QUIZ PDF PAGE REFERENCES)

Question	Quiz PDF page	Concept tested	Type
W2 Q7	p.8	Teleconferencing	MCQ
W2 Q9	p.8	Voice mail	Fill-in-the-blank
W2 Q12	p.9	Voice mail	MSQ

Full question text and answers: Quiz analysis.

Summary

Voice mail replaces short memos, overcomes time zones and cuts paperwork but gives no immediate feedback. Mobile phone etiquette stresses low voice, silence in public places and no odd-hour calls. Teleconferencing connects dispersed people at short notice but is poor for negotiation, while video conferencing adds visuals and has three types; users must manage equipment, speech and body language.

Practice questions

Q1 (MCQ) Teleconferencing is generally ineffective for:

A. Saving travel costs

B. Negotiations

C. Arranging meetings at short notice

D. Connecting dispersed people

> **Answer:** B
> **Why:** Facial reactions and non-verbal cues cannot be read.

Q2 (MCQ) Voice mail helps solve _____ difficulties.

A. Spelling

B. Time zone

C. Language

D. Dress code

> **Answer:** B
> **Why:** Messages can be left when the person cannot be reached.

Q3 (MSQ) Select correct statements about voice mail.

A. It substitutes short memos and calls

B. It solves time-zone problems

C. It increases paperwork

D. It gives immediate specific feedback

> **Answer:** A, B
> **Why:** It reduces paperwork and lacks immediate feedback.

Q4 (T/F) In a video conference you should look at the camera and avoid parallel whispers.

> **Answer:** True
> **Why:** These are listed cautions.

Q5 (Fill) On a cell phone one should speak in a _____ modulated voice.

> **Answer:** low
> **Why:** Loud calls disturb others.

Q6 Short What should a voice mail message include?

> **Answer:** Name, point of the message, phone number and time/date of availability.
> **Why:** Keep it focused on the essentials.

Revision checklist

☐ I can state advantages and limits of voice mail.
☐ I know cell phone etiquette.
☐ I can contrast teleconferencing and video conferencing.
☐ I know the three types of video conferencing.
☐ I remember why teleconferencing fails for negotiation.

Lecture 9: Communicating Without Words

Week 2 · Course book PDF pages 127–147 (printed pages 126–146)

Learning objectives

- Define non-verbal communication and explain why it matters.
- Quote the Birdwhistell and Mehrabian percentages.
- List the types of non-verbal communication: kinesics, proxemics, chronemics, paralanguage, haptics, meta-communication.
- Describe the forms of kinesics: personal appearance, facial expression, eye contact, movement, posture and gesture, with cultural differences.

Important definitions

NON-VERBAL COMMUNICATION

Communication without words, through symbols and cues such as expression, gesture, posture and eye behaviour. It is spontaneous and unintentional, and it supplements and complements verbal communication.

KINESICS

The study of body movement or body language; includes personal appearance, facial expression, eye contact, movement, posture and gesture.

PROXEMICS

Use of space and distance in communication (from *proximity*).

CHRONEMICS

The role of time in communication.

PARALANGUAGE

How words are spoken, beyond the words themselves (voice qualities).

HAPTICS

Communication through touch.

POSTURE

Positioning: how you sit, stand and hold your arms and shoulders.

Core concepts

Verbal and non-verbal proportions

- **Ray Birdwhistell:** 35% of communication is verbal and 65% non-verbal.
- **Mehrabian:** 7% verbal (words), 38% vocal, and the remaining (55%) non-verbal.
- One study counts more than **6 lakh** non-verbal cues, so they are categorised.

Nature of non-verbal cues

- Cannot substitute words (e.g. 'happiness', 'silence') but have **more impact because they are spontaneous**.
- They are **unintentional and unstructured**; posed expressions become stereotyped (as with actors).
- Work at two levels: the verbal level (words) and the non-verbal level.
- People are communicating all the time; even silence has meaning (differs across cultures).
- Symbols and emoticons in chat and email are non-verbal cues.

Types of non-verbal communication

1. **Kinesics** – body language
2. **Proxemics** – space
3. **Chronemics** – time
4. **Paralanguage** – voice
5. **Haptics** – touch
6. **Meta-communication**

Kinesics: sign language (posed, stereotyped), action language (body behaviour) and object language.

Personal appearance and face

- The face is a junction of emotions; 'face is the index of the mind', but 'a false face must have a false heart' when one manipulates.
- Liars find it hard to hide body language (child with clamped hands in pockets).
- Dress should be clean, ironed and suitable; it creates the **first impression**. It need not be expensive.
- Freud: "He who has eyes to see and ears to hear can convince himself that no mortal can keep a secret."
- Chesterton: "There are no uninteresting topics, there are uninteresting people."

Eye contact

- Eyes are 'the mirror of the heart and windows of the soul'; they show sincerity, honesty and conviction and establish rapport and credibility.
- Culture-specific: Arabs, Latin Americans and southern Europeans gaze at the face; Asians, Indians, Pakistanis and northern Europeans prefer peripheral gaze or none (Harper, Wiens and Matarazzo).
- Eye contact should be neither a gaze nor a stare.
- Herodotus: "Men trust their ears less than their eyes."
- Glowering looks and checking watches show the audience is bored.

Movement and posture

- Do not rush; avoid excessive or distracting movement; move gracefully.

- Dale Carnegie: people form an impression from how you dress, walk, sit and stand.
- Posture: do not recline; avoid hands in pockets, clamped hands, playing with key rings, shuffling.

Gestures

- Gestures back up language; do not repeat the same gesture (e.g. thumping the desk).
- Types: enumerative and symbolic gestures.
- **Limp hands** – boredom; **flat hands** – silent questions; **open hands** – welcome; **clenched hands** – tension/frustration; **fist** – determination; **crossed arms** – negative; **crossed legs** – insulting to the audience.
- Handshakes: glove handshake (politician); dead-fish handshake (formal/unwilling).
- Gestures differ by culture: 'come here' in the US may mean 'go away' in Italy.

Types, classifications and characteristics

Types of non-verbal communication

Type	Concerned with
Kinesics	Body movement
Proxemics	Space and distance
Chronemics	Time
Paralanguage	How words are spoken
Haptics	Touch
Meta-communication	Meaning beyond words

Forms of kinesics

Form	Notes
Personal appearance	Dress, grooming; first impression
Facial expression	Junction of emotions
Eye contact	Rapport, credibility; culture-specific
Movement / posture	Graceful, not excessive; alert positioning
Gesture	Supports speech; meanings vary across cultures

Theories, principles, models and contributors

VERBAL VERSUS NON-VERBAL SHARE — RAY BIRDWHISTELL

35% verbal, 65% non-verbal.

7-38-55 SPLIT — MEHRABIAN

7% verbal, 38% vocal, remainder non-verbal.

THREE LANGUAGES OF KINESICS — AUTHOR CITED IN LECTURE

Sign language, action language and object language.

Examples and applications

EXAMPLE

A mute beggar’s face conveyed happiness on receiving a coin.

EXAMPLE

A child who lies hides clamped hands in his pockets.

EXAMPLE

‘Come here’ gesture in the US means ‘go away’ in Italy.

EXAMPLE

A speaker whose audience keeps checking watches should change delivery.

Comparison tables

Birdwhistell versus Mehrabian

Point	Birdwhistell	Mehrabian
Verbal	35%	7%
Vocal	Not separated	38%
Non-verbal	65%	Remaining (55%)

Hand gestures and meanings

Gesture	Usual meaning
Limp hands	Boredom
Flat hands	Silent questions
Open hands	Welcome
Clenched hands	Tension, frustration
Fist	Determination
Crossed arms	Negative attitude

Important facts for MCQ revision

EXAM TIP

- Birdwhistell: 35% verbal, 65% non-verbal.
- Mehrabian: 7% verbal, 38% vocal, rest non-verbal.
- More than 6 lakh non-verbal cues.
- Non-verbal communication is spontaneous and unintentional.
- Kinesics = body language; proxemics = space; chronemics = time; haptics = touch.
- Kinesics forms: appearance, facial expression, eye contact, posture, gesture, movement.
- Eye contact: Arabs, Latin Americans and southern Europeans gaze; Asians prefer peripheral gaze.
- Herodotus: men trust their ears less than their eyes.
- Dale Carnegie: people judge how you dress, walk, sit and stand.
- Glove handshake: politician; dead-fish handshake: formal or unwilling.

QUIZ-RELATED CONCEPTS (QUIZ PDF PAGE REFERENCES)

Question	Quiz PDF page	Concept tested	Type
W0 Q2	p.1	Non-verbal communication	MCQ
W0 Q4	p.1	Positive body language	MCQ
W2 Q3	p.7	Mehrabian's 7-38-55 rule	MCQ
W2 Q15	p.9	Hand gestures (kinesics)	Match the columns

Full question text and answers: Quiz analysis.

Summary

Non-verbal communication complements words and is spontaneous and unintentional. Birdwhistell put it at 65% and Mehrabian at 55% with 38% vocal. Its categories are kinesics, proxemics, chronemics, paralanguage, haptics and meta-communication. Kinesics covers appearance, face, eyes, movement, posture and gestures, all of which vary by culture and must be controlled to create a favourable impression.

Practice questions

Q1 (MCQ) According to Mehrabian, the vocal element accounts for:

A. 7%

B. 38%

C. 55%

D. 65%

> **Answer:** B
> **Why:** 7% verbal, 38% vocal, 55% non-verbal.

Q2 (MCQ) The study of space in communication is:

A. Kinesics

B. Haptics

C. Proxemics

D. Chronemics

> **Answer:** C
> **Why:** Derived from proximity.

Q3 (MSQ) Which are forms of kinesics?

A. Eye contact

B. Posture

C. Touch

D. Gesture

> **Answer:** A, B, D
> **Why:** Touch belongs to haptics.

Q4 (T/F) Non-verbal cues can completely substitute for words.

> **Answer:** False
> **Why:** They supplement, not substitute.

Q5 (Fill) Clenched hands indicate _____ and frustration.

> **Answer:** tension
> **Why:** A fist signals determination.

Q6 (Short) Why is eye contact culture-specific?

> **Answer:** Some cultures gaze at the face; others, e.g. Asian, prefer peripheral gaze and treat direct gaze as impolite.
> **Why:** Avoid both gaze and stare.

Revision checklist

☐ I know both percentage splits.

☐ I can list the six types of non-verbal communication.

☐ I can list the forms of kinesics.

☐ I know hand-gesture meanings.

☐ I remember the cultural differences in eye contact.

Lecture 10: Paralanguage

Week 2 · Course book PDF pages 148–167 (printed pages 147–166)

Learning objectives

- Define paralanguage and list the features of voice: quality, volume, rate, pitch, pronunciation, pauses and silence.
- Identify voice faults: throatiness, breathiness, nasalisation, harshness, muffling and hoarseness.
- State the ideal speaking rate and how to improve articulation.
- Explain intonation, stress, pauses, silence and the quotations of Mark Twain and Pythagoras.

Important definitions

PARALANGUAGE

The study of how words are spoken: the vocal characteristics (quality, volume, rate, pitch, pronunciation, pauses) that add meaning beyond the words.

ARTICULATION

Producing speech sounds clearly through the speech organs; clarity is the hallmark of communication.

AUDIBILITY

The ability of the listener to hear the speaker; related to volume.

INTONATION

The rises and falls in the voice.

INFLECTION

Changes in pitch produced by vibration of the vocal cords while speaking; they convey feelings.

PAUSE

A short silence in speech that separates units of thought; a longer pause becomes silence.

RECEIVED PRONUNCIATION (RP)

The standard pronunciation recommended for clear, intelligible speech instead of imitating Americans or Britons.

Core concepts

Why voice matters

- Everyone's voice is unique and carries intentional and unintentional emotions.
- The **quality** of voice can be improved by training (Lincoln and Churchill had voice problems).
- Speech production passes through stages starting with the **articulatory–respiratory** process using lips, teeth, nasal passage, windpipe.
- English as a second or third language causes translation lapses and pronunciation problems.

Features of voice

1. **Quality** – check audibility; neither too loud nor too slow.
2. **Volume** – degree of loudness; adjust to audience size and room acoustics (no shouting for 20–30 people).
3. **Rate** – adjust to the audience's background.
4. **Pitch** – variations and inflections.
5. **Pronunciation**.
6. **Pauses and silence**.

Rate of speech

- Ideal average: **140–150 words per minute** (the lecturer also advises at least 130–150).
- Too fast: you forget and run out of material; too slow: boredom. Follow the **'madhyam marga'** (middle path).
- Imagine an audience of ordinary, moderately educated people.

Faults of voice

- **Throatiness** – deep resonance in the throat.
- **Breathiness** – too much air through the vocal cords.
- **Nasalisation** – air released through the nose.
- **Harshness** – uninhibited flow of air.
- **Muffling** – lazy lip and jaw movement.
- **Hoarseness** – inflammation of the larynx; a medical problem, consult a speech therapist.

Improving the voice

- Speak distinctly; avoid chopping, slurring and mumbling ('gonna', 'wanna', 'dunno', 'otta', 'dint') and fillers (ah, um).
- Record yourself on a mobile phone and rehearse.
- Use a dictionary, thesaurus and phonetic notation for difficult words.
- Follow Received Pronunciation; learn from good news anchors; listen actively.
- Vary pitch to avoid monotony; use intonation.

Stress and intonation

- Content words (nouns, adjectives, verbs, adverbs) take stress; **articles, prepositions, conjunctions, auxiliary verbs and personal pronouns usually do not**.
- Stress the correct syllable (use a dictionary).

- **Falling tone** for commands and wh-questions ('Bring me a cup of tea', 'Where had you been?').
- **Rising tone** for requests and yes/no questions and question tags.
- Modulate voice to express intended meaning (the late student seeking permission).

Pauses and silence

- Pauses separate units of thought; begin and end a speech with a pause.
- **Mark Twain:** "The right word may be effective, but no word was ever as effective as a rightly timed pause."
- A longer pause becomes silence; silence is a non-verbal cue with different meanings across cultures (approval, disapproval, disagreement).
- Silence helps thinking, introspection and decision-making for both speaker and listener.
- **Pythagoras:** "Silence is better than unmeaning words."

Types, classifications and characteristics

Voice faults

Fault	Cause
Throatiness	Deep resonance in the throat
Breathiness	Too much air through vocal cords
Nasalisation	Air released through the nose
Harshness	Uninhibited air flow
Muffling	Lazy lips and jaw
Hoarseness	Inflammation of the larynx (medical)

Features of voice

Feature	Meaning
Quality	Overall character and audibility
Volume	Loudness or softness
Rate	Speed (140–150 wpm)
Pitch	Rise and fall; inflection
Pronunciation	Clear sounds; correct stress
Pauses	Short silences between thought units

Theories, principles, models and contributors

> **MARK TWAIN ON THE PAUSE — MARK TWAIN**
>
> "The right word may be effective, but no word was ever as effective as a rightly timed pause."

SILENCE IS BETTER THAN UNMEANING WORDS — PYTHAGORAS

Quoted at the close of the lecture.

Examples and applications

EXAMPLE

Lincoln and Churchill overcame voice problems through training.

EXAMPLE

Late student: “May I come in, sir, though I am late, sir?” shows intended meaning through voice.

EXAMPLE

BBC English, Hindi and Bangla services as models of pleasant voices.

EXAMPLE

Falling tone: “Where had you been?”; rising tone: “Is it time to wind up, isn’t it?”

Comparison tables

Falling versus rising tone

Falling tone	Rising tone
Commands: Bring me a cup of tea	Requests: Would you like tea with me?
Wh-questions: Where had you been?	Yes/no questions and tags: Isn’t it?

Pause versus silence

Pause	Silence
Short gap between units of thought	Longer gap that adds meaning or lets listeners reflect
Used within speech	Interpreted differently across cultures

Important facts for MCQ revision

EXAM TIP

- Ideal rate is about 140–150 words per minute.
- Pitch changes are called inflections; rises and falls in the voice are intonation.
- Voice faults: throatiness, breathiness, nasalisation, harshness, muffling, hoarseness.
- Hoarseness results from inflammation of the larynx; consult a speech therapist.
- Articles, prepositions, conjunctions, auxiliaries and personal pronouns do not take stress.
- Mark Twain on the rightly timed pause.
- Pythagoras: Silence is better than unmeaning words.
- Clarity is the hallmark of communication.
- Follow Received Pronunciation rather than imitating Americans or British.

QUIZ-RELATED CONCEPTS (QUIZ PDF PAGE REFERENCES)

Question	Quiz PDF page	Concept tested	Type
W2 Q4	p.7	Voice faults	MCQ
W2 Q8	p.8	Paralanguage: pitch and inflection	Fill-in-the-blank
W2 Q14	p.9	Characteristics of voice	MSQ

Full question text and answers: Quiz analysis.

Summary

Paralanguage covers voice quality, volume, rate, pitch, pronunciation and pauses. Speakers should speak at about 140–150 words per minute, vary pitch to avoid monotony, articulate each sound distinctly, follow Received Pronunciation, stress content words and use pauses and silence intentionally. Voice faults such as throatiness, breathiness, nasalisation, harshness, muffling and hoarseness can be reduced by training, except hoarseness, which is medical.

Practice questions

Q1 (MCQ) Hoarseness results from:

A. Lazy lips

B. Inflammation of the larynx

C. Too much nasal air

D. Fast speech

> **Answer:** B
> **Why:** It is a medical problem needing a speech therapist.

Q2 (MCQ) The ideal speaking rate suggested is:

A. 80–100 wpm

B. 140–150 wpm

C. 200–220 wpm

D. Any speed

> **Answer:** B
> **Why:** This is the balanced rate.

Q3 (MSQ) Which words usually do NOT take stress?

A. Articles

B. Prepositions

C. Nouns

D. Conjunctions

> **Answer:** A, B, D
> **Why:** Nouns, adjectives, verbs and adverbs take stress.

Q4 (T/F) Changes in pitch while speaking are called inflections.

> **Answer:** True
> **Why:** They convey feelings.

Q5 (Fill) The ‘middle path’ in speech rate is called _____.

> **Answer:** madhyam marga
> **Why:** Neither too fast nor too slow.

Q6 (Short) Why should a speaker use pauses?

> **Answer:** They separate units of thought, give emphasis, let listeners absorb the message and help the speaker think.
> **Why:** Mark Twain valued a rightly timed pause.

Revision checklist

☐ I can list the features of voice.

☐ I know the voice faults and causes.

☐ I remember 140–150 wpm.

☐ I know which words take stress and which tones fall or rise.

☐ I can quote Mark Twain and Pythagoras.